



In need of an overhaul

ECI's response is mere damage control, the SIRs ill-effects must be undone

The Election Commission of India's (ECI) press note on Saturday, following revelations that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had recorded 14 objections to decisions under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, reads like damage control to manage perceptions. It concedes their complaints, but only administrative ones. Agenda will be circulated before meetings, and the minutes afterwards, while officers' foreign trips will require the ECI's approval. It also implicitly admits the flawed implementation of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) are to launch a "special drive" to enrol anyone "whose name has got left out". But there is no remorse for an exercise that struck lakhs of genuine electors off the rolls in West Bengal and has marauded from State to State. Those deleted are simply asked to reapply as though they were new applicants. There is no answer to Mr. Sandhu's question on who authorised 16.1 lakh appeals to remove voters whom judicial officers had included in West Bengal.

India's institutions have largely held, except in dark periods such as the Emergency, when an executive emboldened by legislative strength ran roughshod over the Constitution and a shamelessly permissive judiciary let it do so via *ADM Jabalpur*. The ECI under Mr. Kumar has overseen the removal of more than 13 crore names from draft rolls through the SIR which, as this daily has repeatedly argued, shifts the onus of enrolment from the state to the elector, deletes names before it verifies and imposes onerous conditions for re-entry. It got away with this because the Supreme Court declined for months to decide whether the exercise was constitutional. When it finally ruled on May 27, the SIR was already a settled fact in Bihar, West Bengal and other Phase 2 States. The judgment, reminiscent of *ADM Jabalpur*'s deference to the state, engaged the SIR in theory and not in practice. It read a provision for exceptional, targeted revisions as a licence for a State-wide sweep. While it assured voters already on the rolls that they were still presumed eligible, the SIR made them prove it all over again. And it brushed aside its 1995 ruling that every removal must be individually reasoned. Events since then indicate the damage done – over nine in 10 appeals decided by West Bengal's tribunals have restored deleted voters months after the Assembly polls; and in one third of Delhi's seats, the draft rolls have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025. The ECI's press note changes very little. The ECI must be reconstituted by a selection committee that does not give the government an overriding majority. Anything less would be a travesty of institutional democracy.

New equilibrium

As the U.S. and China recalibrate ties, implications for other nations are huge

On the surface, Chinese President Xi Jinping's Washington visit appeared to be more about ceremony than substance. President Donald Trump rolled out the red carpet, personally welcoming the Chinese leader at the base where he landed. The last time that a U.S. President accorded such an honour to a foreign leader was when John F. Kennedy welcomed British Prime Minister Harold MacMillan in 1962. Mr. Trump also laid out a grand state dinner at the White House, inviting some of the biggest names in tech and business in the U.S. Beyond the optics, the concrete outcomes from the Trump-Xi talks were modest. The most immediate one was an agreement for both leaders to meet twice this year at the APEC summit in Shenzhen and the G-20 in Miami, marking an unusual four meetings in one year, with Mr. Trump having visited Beijing in May. Both sides also agreed to operationalise a board of trade and investment. No new trade agreement was reached, although both have extended for another two months the trade truce agreed to at Busan last year as well as an arrangement for a \$30 billion reciprocal tariff reduction. China reaffirmed its commitment to buy \$17 billion worth of agricultural products annually, but offered no new ones. Other long pending issues such as semiconductors, rare earths and U.S. arms sales to Taiwan appear deferred for now. Both did, however, announce the establishment of a new dialogue on Artificial Intelligence and the opening of a channel for incidents, amid growing concerns over the consequences of an unregulated AI race.

The modest outcomes from the Xi visit should not obscure the broader shift that recent U.S.-China engagement has underlined. The agreement between the world's two biggest powers to pursue what they call a constructive relationship of strategic stability based on fairness, respect and reciprocity points to a new equilibrium. Their relationship certainly remains beset by serious structural challenges and will remain one marked by rivalry. At the same time, both sides appear eager to set a floor to ensure a rivalry that is more managed, stable and predictable. Countries in the region will be watching closely how this may temper an "America First" Washington's appetite to push back against China in waters far from home. New Delhi will need to carefully watch this evolving new equilibrium. The recent U.S. tariff threats aimed at India have offered a stark contrast to the measured language with which Washington has been engaging Beijing. For long, a strand of Indian strategic thinking has been predicated on the assumption that U.S. strategy in the region was centred on the idea of a relationship with India as a bulwark against Chinese influence. That assumption increasingly appears open to question.

India stands at a critical demographic crossroads. With one of the world's largest youth populations, the country possesses an immense economic advantage. Yet, a youthful population becomes a genuine demographic dividend only when young citizens are educated, skilled, gainfully employed and provided with meaningful opportunities. Otherwise, that demographic promise risks turning into social disillusionment.

China, despite its comparable population, is moving in the opposite demographic direction. Decades of low fertility have accelerated the ageing of its population. India, by contrast, possesses an extraordinary reservoir of young people entering the workforce. The central question is whether the country can create the economic opportunities and infrastructure needed to harness this potential.

The aspiration-reality gap

The smartphone revolution has intensified this challenge. A young person in a town or remote village can now see within seconds how the rest of the world lives, studies, works and travels. Global possibilities are visible on high-definition screens, even as tangible opportunities remain painfully out of reach.

This has created a widening divide between aspiration and reality. The horizons of young Indians have expanded far faster than the institutions and economies around them. Access to higher education has widened, yet meaningful employment opportunities have not kept pace. A college degree is no longer a guarantee of a job, leaving many without financial security or the dignity that comes with economic independence. When heightened aspirations collide with limited opportunities, frustration inevitably follows, often finding expression in protests over recruitment, examination irregularities, examination and test paper leaks, unemployment and systemic failures.

Kashmiri youth share these aspirations but carry a compounding historical burden. Decades of conflict, political uncertainty and economic isolation have deepened their sense of insecurity and constrained their opportunities. Too often, young Kashmiris have been viewed through a narrow security lens, as potential liabilities rather than national assets.

Yet, Jammu and Kashmir, like the rest of India, has a large young population with its own aspirations. Its youth seek the same basic things as young people elsewhere: economic



Mehbooba Mufti

President, Jammu and Kashmir Peoples Democratic Party (PDP)

Reconnecting Kashmir's historic routes could unlock economic opportunities for its youth

independence, dignity, opportunity and a future in which they are not permanently viewed with suspicion.

Jammu and Kashmir possesses an exceptional combination of natural wealth and geographic significance. Its rivers offer substantial hydroelectric potential, its mountains contain valuable mineral resources, and its landscapes sustain a major tourism economy. Yet, its most underutilised strategic asset may be its location.

Focus on Kashmir's historic crossroads

For centuries, Kashmir was never a cul-de-sac. It was a thriving crossroads. Historic caravan routes linked Kashmir and Ladakh with Central Asia, Tibet and the broader Indian subcontinent. These routes carried far more than merchandise. They connected people, ideas, philosophies, literature, cultures and skills. The arrival of Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani, revered as Shah-i-Hamadan, is deeply embedded in Kashmiri history and is traditionally associated with the arrival of Persian and Central Asian craftsmen who enriched Kashmir's celebrated handicraft traditions. The historical lesson is clear: connectivity creates economic ecosystems.

Today, Indian strategic thinking needs to look beyond the immediate constraints posed by the Line of Control with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control with China. Where political and security conditions permit, India needs a pragmatic framework to gradually restore Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh to the role they historically occupied: that of a bridge connecting South Asia with Central Asia and the wider Eurasian landmass.

For this, India needs a diplomatic road map alongside its infrastructure road map. Reopening traditional routes towards Pakistan or Central Asia cannot happen without sustained engagement with neighbouring countries. With Pakistan, the objective should be to explore confidence-building measures and trade connectivity wherever feasible. With China, India should pursue practical dialogue on trans-Himalayan connectivity wherever economic interests and security concerns can be reconciled.

This transition could begin with a phased connectivity strategy. India should identify historically important trade corridors that could eventually be revived as modern economic corridors, beginning with those where security and diplomatic conditions are most conducive. This does not mean opening every route at once.

The paradox of de-Sinification in global production

SpaceX's reported efforts, in July 2026, to remove Chinese-made components from its supply chain capture a new phase in the restructuring of global production. The challenge is no longer simply where a product is assembled. It is increasingly about what lies several layers beneath the final manufacturer – and whether firms can identify, replace and verify suppliers embedded deep within complex production networks. Moving a factory may be relatively straightforward; removing an industrial ecosystem from the production process is not.

The other side of de-Sinification

Here lies a less noticed paradox. The ecosystem problem is not confined to foreign firms seeking to reduce their exposure to China. Chinese companies expanding overseas increasingly confront it from the opposite direction. While foreign firms struggle to disentangle themselves from Chinese suppliers and capabilities, Chinese firms must decide how much of the industrial ecosystem that supports their competitiveness at home can be carried abroad and how much must be recreated locally.

This difficulty is compounded by the fact that China's industrial ecosystem is not standing still. Even as foreign firms seek to reduce their dependence on China, China is building capabilities in areas where it has historically relied heavily on foreign technology. Memory-chip maker CXMT is illustrative. It has emerged as the world's fourth-largest producer of DRAM chips, although it continues to trail global leaders in advanced memory technologies and remains dependent on access to foreign chipmaking equipment. Attempts to reduce exposure to China are therefore taking place against a moving target: Chinese firms are simultaneously working to reduce their own external dependencies.

The reverse challenge becomes visible when Chinese manufacturers venture overseas. They too confront a form of de-Sinification, although from the opposite direction. Their internationalisation increasingly involves more than establishing final-assembly plants. The



G. Venkat Raman

Professor, Humanities and Social Sciences, Indian Institute of Management, Indore, Madhya Pradesh

De-Sinification is reshaping factories, but industrial ecosystems remain harder to move

competitiveness of companies such as BYD and Xpeng rests partly on dense networks of component makers, engineering capabilities and production relationships developed within China. Moving a factory abroad therefore creates a choice: take existing suppliers along, cultivate new local suppliers, or combine the two. Each route carries different costs – and produces a different degree of genuine localisation.

The challenge beyond factories

BYD's expansion in Europe illustrates one response. As it builds manufacturing capacity in Hungary, the company is also developing relationships with European suppliers. Xpeng has chosen another route, contracting Canadian automotive supplier Magna to assemble its vehicles in Austria. The two approaches differ, but they expose the same underlying problem: producing outside China is easier than reproducing outside China, the ecosystem that made production in China efficient in the first place.

What makes these ecosystems difficult to unwind or reproduce is that they consist of more than identifiable suppliers. They embody accumulated relationships between firms, specialised skills, tooling and production knowledge, logistics networks, and the ability of suppliers to respond quickly when designs or production volumes change. Many of these advantages are built through repeated interaction rather than formal contracts. This is why replacing an individual Chinese supplier does not necessarily eliminate dependence on the wider Chinese production system – and why transplanting a Chinese factory abroad does not automatically transplant the capabilities surrounding it.

Seen from this perspective, de-Sinification has a less obvious, two-sided character. Foreign firms attempting to reduce their exposure to China confront the depth of China's integration into their production networks. Chinese firms going global confront the difficulty of reproducing abroad the ecosystem on which their competitiveness depends. One side is trying to

Pilot corridors could be developed and expanded progressively on the basis of experience.

Security cannot be ignored in any such endeavour. But security and connectivity need not automatically be treated as opposing objectives. Properly regulated connectivity can create greater economic interdependence and potentially provide stronger incentives for stability.

The same principle should guide India's approach to Central Asia. Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh could become India's northern economic gateway, giving Indian businesses greater access to Central Asian markets while bringing investment, tourism and commerce to the region. The benefits would extend far beyond Kashmir.

A road to opportunity

A functioning land corridor creates opportunities at every stage, from construction, transport and warehousing to hospitality, manufacturing, agriculture, logistics, finance, technology and services. Unlike air connectivity, whose economic benefits are concentrated around a limited number of nodes, a trade corridor can generate economic activity across a wider geography through which it passes.

Most importantly, it could give the young people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh something far more valuable than another promise. It could give them wings to fly towards new horizons.

India's demographic advantage is a window of opportunity, not a permanent condition. We cannot afford to allow a generation to grow up watching possibilities on smartphones while encountering closed doors in the real world.

For Jammu and Kashmir, the answer may lie partly in reopening doors that history once kept open. The Silk Road was never only about silk. It was about the movement of goods, people, ideas and possibilities.

It is time to view Kashmir not merely through the prism of conflict, but through the lens of enterprise, connectivity and integration. Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee spoke of abandoning beaten paths and searching for new ways to address difficult issues. The ancient roads across the Himalayas do not belong merely in history books. Reimagined as modern economic arteries, they could become pathways to opportunity, giving the next generation not another reason to wait, but a road towards a better future.

disentangle itself from an ecosystem; the other is trying to make that ecosystem portable. Both discover that changing the location of production is easier than changing the capabilities and relationships that sustain it.

What India needs to note, must build

This distinction matters particularly for India. The reorganisation of production is already creating openings. Japan's TDK has expanded its battery production in Haryana, deepening an Indian manufacturing base that it has been developing as part of its broader China-plus-one strategy. Murata Manufacturing, another Japanese electronic-component maker, is expanding its manufacturing presence in India. These investments show that India is beginning to receive parts of production ecosystems previously concentrated in China. But making the most of this opening requires more than attracting individual factories. India needs domestic suppliers capable of meeting demanding cost, quality and delivery standards, alongside reliable logistics, skilled workers and access to critical inputs. The test is whether new investments progressively deepen linkages with Indian firms and bring specialised capabilities and intermediate production into the domestic economy. The same principle should inform Chinese investment: its value should be judged partly by the capabilities and supplier networks it develops locally. India's opportunity is to convert the movement of factories into the gradual accumulation of an industrial ecosystem of its own.

The emerging geography of global production will therefore be shaped by more than decisions over where to locate factories. It will depend on whether the ecosystems behind those factories can be dismantled, transferred or rebuilt. De-Sinification may be visible in new factory locations and investment announcements, but its real test lies deeper within the production system. Factories can cross borders relatively quickly; industrial ecosystems, built through accumulated capabilities and relationships, are far less mobile.